

The Verse:

וַיֵּרֶד מִצְרָיִם

אֲרָמִי אֲבִד אֲבִי וַיֵּרֶד
מִצְרָיִם וַיֵּגֶר שָׁם בְּמִתִּי מֵעַט
וַיְהִי שָׁם לְגוֹי גָּדוֹל עָצוּם וְרַב:

“An Aramean [tried to] destroy my forefather, and he went down to Egypt and he sojourned there with a small number of people, and there, he became a great, mighty, and numerous nation.”

“and he went down to Egypt”

Jacob didn't go down to Egypt by choice. Instead, he was predestined to go as G-d foretold Abraham at the “covenant between the parts.”

1

וַיֵּגֶר שָׁם

“and he sojourned there”

This teaches us that Jacob and his family had a short stay in mind, only until the end of the harsh famine. Indeed, when they arrived in Egypt, Jacob's sons said to Pharaoh “we have come to sojourn in the land because there is no pasture for our sheep, for the famine is severe in the land of Cana'an.”

בְּמִתִּי מֵעַט

“with a small number”

The Torah says: “Your fathers went down to Egypt with seventy persons, and now, Hashem, your G-d, has made you as numerous as the stars of heaven.”

According to the census taken in the desert, between two and three million Jews left during the exodus from Egypt.

2

3

וַיְהִי שֵׁם לְגוֹי

***“and he became
a nation there”***

This teaches us that the Children of Israel stood out as a distinctive people and did not assimilate into the majority Egyptian culture.

The Jewish people kept their Hebrew names and language, their religious observances and their unique style of dress. This enabled them to retain their distinct identity.

4

וַיִּרְבּוּ

“and numerous”

The prophet Ezekiel describes the Jewish people in Egypt alone and abandoned. No nation in the world would come to their aid, only G-d came to rescue them.

G-d caused the Children of Israel to flourish. In the words of the prophet, “Myriads, like the plants of the fields, I have made you, and you have increased and grown....”

6

גָּדוֹל עֲצוּם

“great and mighty”

The Torah says: "And the Children of Israel were fruitful and increased abundantly, and multiplied and became very, very mighty, and the land became filled with them.

Rashi, the classic commentator, explains that the Jewish women bore six children at each birth!

5

The Verse:

וַיִּרְעוּ אֹתָנוּ הַמִּצְרִים וַיַּעֲנוּנוּ
וַיִּתְּנוּ עָלֵינוּ עֲבָדָה קָשָׁה:

***“And the Egyptians treated us
cruelly and afflicted us, and they
imposed hard labor upon us.”***

וַיַּרְעוּ אֶת־נוּ אֶת־הַמִּצְרִים

“And the Egyptians treated us cruelly”

Pharaoh said, “Come, let us act cunningly with [the Jews] lest they multiply and overtake us.”

The Jews were asked to volunteer in the construction of storage cities. They agreed and worked hard to impress their hosts. At the conclusion of the workday, the Egyptians tallied their work and commanded them to return the next day to perform the same amount of labor. And so the slavery began...

1

וַיִּתְּנוּ עָלֵינוּ עֲבָדָה קָשָׁה:

“and they imposed hard labor upon us”

The Torah says: “The Egyptians made the children of Israel work with rigor. And they made their lives bitter with hard work, with mortar and bricks and all types of work in the field...”

3

וַיַּעֲנוּנוּ

“and they afflicted us”

The Torah says:

“They set taskmasters over [the people of Israel] to make them suffer with their burdens, and they built storage cities for Pharaoh, Pitom and Ramses.”

2

The Verse:

וַנִּצְעַק אֶל ה' אֱלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ
וַיִּשְׁמַע ה' אֶת קִלְנוּ וַיֵּרָא אֶת
עֲנִינוּ וְאֶת עֲמָלְנוּ וְאֶת לַחֲצֵנוּ:

“So we cried out to Hashem, G-d of our fathers, and He saw our affliction, our toil, and our oppression.”

וַנִּצְעַק אֶל ה' אֱלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ

***“we cried out to Hashem,
G-d of our fathers”***

The Torah says: "During that long period, the king of Egypt died; and the children of Israel groaned because of the servitude, and they cried out. And their cry for help from their servitude rose up to G-d."

1

וַיֵּרָא אֶת עַנְיֵינוּ

“and He saw our affliction”

This refers to the forced separation of husband and wife.

The Egyptian taskmasters overloaded the Jewish slaves with work to the point of sheer exhaustion. Thus, they were prevented from returning home each evening and forced to sleep at the work site.

3

וַיִּשְׁמַע ה' אֶת קִלְנוּ

***“and Hashem
heard our voice”***

The Torah say: "And G-d heard their groaning, and G-d remembered His covenant with Abraham, Isaac and Jacob."

400 years earlier, G-d had promised Abraham that He would not forsake the Jewish people and would redeem them from their oppression.

2

וְאֶת עֲמָלֵנוּ

“and our toil”

This refers to the decree against Jewish children, as it is said: "Every boy that is born, you shall throw into the river and every girl you shall keep alive."

The Jewish parents toiled and invested energy in raising their children to blossom both materially and spiritually.

Pharaoh intended to physically exterminate the Jewish boys, while the girls were to be “let live” in the depraved and immoral Egyptian society.

4

וְאֵת לַחֲצֵנוּ

“and our oppression”

G-d said: "I have seen the oppression with which the Egyptians oppress them."

The word “pressure” can refer to physical duress, as well as psychological abuse. The Jews were subject to both. Their masters not only forced them to perform back-breaking work, they also oppressed them emotionally and psychologically, never allowing them any respite or tranquility.

5

וַיּוֹצֵאֵנוּ ה' מִמִּצְרַיִם

“And Hashem brought us out from Egypt”

Unlike other great miracles that were performed through an angel or human messenger, the Exodus from Egypt was brought about directly by G-d Himself.

Indeed, G-d says in the Torah: “In that night I will pass through the land of Egypt, and I will smite every first-born in the land of Egypt, from man to beast, and I will carry out judgments against all the gods of Egypt, I Hashem.”

1

The Verse:

וַיּוֹצֵאֵנוּ ה' מִמִּצְרַיִם בְּיָד
חֲזָקָה וּבְזְרֹעַ נְטוּיָה וּבְמָרָא
גָּדֹל וּבְאֵתוֹת וּבְמִפְתִּים:

And Hashem brought us out from Egypt with a strong hand and with an outstretched arm, with a great vision, with signs and wonders.

בְּיָד חֲזָקָה

“with a strong hand”

This refers to the plague of pestilence.

The Torah says: "Behold, the hand of Hashem will be upon your livestock in the field, upon the horses, the donkeys, the camels, the herds and the flocks, a very severe pestilence."

2

וּבְזֶרַע נְטוּיָה

“with an outstretched arm”

This refers to the divine sword, i.e. the plague of death against the Egyptian firstborn.

G-d 's retribution upon Egypt took place in three stages, He first smote their deity, the Nile river; then He destroyed their cattle. Finally, He killed their firstborn.

Although the Egyptians denied G-d's power and providence, He demonstrated His absolute dominion over the world.

3

וּבֵּאתוֹת

“and with signs”

This refers to Moses' staff, as the Torah says: "Take into your hand this staff with which you shall perform the signs."

G-d demonstrated miraculous signs that Moses was to show to Pharaoh – even before the ten plagues commenced. Moses threw his staff on the ground, and behold, it turned into a snake. When he grabbed the tail, it turned back into a stick.

5

וּבְמִרְא גָדֹל

“with a great vision”

This refers to the revelation of the *Shechinah* (the Divine Presence).

As the Jews as they were set to enter Israel, Moses told them: "Has any G-d ever tried to take for himself a nation from the midst of another nation, with trials, signs and wonders, with war and with a strong hand and an outstretched arm, and with great revelations, like all that Hashem your G-d, did for you in Egypt before your eyes!"

4

וּבְמִפְתִּים

“and with wonders”

This refers to the plague of blood, as the Torah says: "And I shall show wonders in heaven and on earth, blood and fire, and pillars of smoke."

The great accomplishment mentioned here is not only the plague of blood itself, but that this first plague awakened in the Jewish people their faith in G-d.

6